



Lost Dogs Ayrshire

RAILWAYS

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)

Date issued	09/07/26
Written by	Darren Hunt
Version	1.0
Review date	09/07/28



1. Purpose

The purpose of this Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) is to provide clear guidance and establish a safe, consistent approach for Lost Dogs Ayrshire volunteers responding to reports of missing or loose dogs in or near railway environments.

Railway infrastructure presents significant and often unpredictable hazards, including high-speed train movements, restricted access areas, limited escape routes, uneven terrain, and the potential for serious injury or fatality. As a result, incidents involving railway lines must be treated as high-risk situations requiring a safety-led response.

2. First Principle

Railways are life-threatening environments.

At no time must any volunteer enter railway property or place themselves at risk to rescue a dog. Volunteer safety always takes absolute priority over the recovery of the dog.

Volunteers must never:

- Enter railway tracks or railway property under any circumstances.
- Follow a dog onto railway land or embankments.
- Attempt recovery on foot within railway environments.
- Cross tracks to access a dog.
- Stand in unsafe proximity to railway lines, platforms, bridges, or tunnels.
- Interfere with railway operations in any way.

Volunteers should only observe from a safe and lawful distance.

2.1 Managing Public Interaction and External Pressure

When attending incidents involving members of the public, volunteers should be aware that high-stress situations may result in urgency, emotional responses, or unintentional pressure to act immediately.

Members of the public may request or encourage volunteers to take action that falls outside safe operating procedures. Volunteers must remain professional, explain the need for a safe approach, and must not allow external pressure to influence their decision-making.

During any high-stress rescue situation:

- Volunteers must not take unnecessary risks to satisfy requests from members of the public.
- Volunteers have the authority to pause, withdraw, or request additional support if they believe the situation is unsafe.
- A safe and controlled response is always preferable to a rushed response that creates additional risk.

3. Initial Scene Assessment

Upon receiving a report or arriving at the location, volunteers should establish:

- The exact location of the dog.
- Whether the dog is on or near railway property.
- The nearest station, bridge, level crossing, or other landmark.
- Whether trains are operating or expected in the area.
- Whether any member of the public has entered, or is attempting to enter, the railway environment.
- The dog's behaviour and direction of travel.
- Any immediate hazards to the public or volunteers.

No action should be taken until the situation has been assessed and it is safe to proceed.

4. Dynamic Risk Assessment

A dynamic risk assessment must be carried out before any action is taken and continually reviewed throughout the incident.

The assessment should consider:

- Whether the dog is on or near live railway infrastructure.
- Current or expected train movements.
- Type of railway line (mainline, freight, rural, station environment).
- Visibility, weather conditions, and time of day.
- Accessibility and terrain, including fencing, embankments, bridges, and tunnels.
- The dog's behaviour and movement patterns.
- Risks to volunteers, members of the public, and railway operations.

If there is any doubt regarding safety, volunteers must withdraw and report the matter to the appropriate authorities.

5. Escalation and Contacting

British Transport Police / Emergency Services

If there is an immediate risk to life, or if a person has entered railway property:

- Call 999 and request Police Scotland or British Transport Police.

Provide:

- Exact location, including the nearest station, bridge, level crossing, or landmark.
- Direction of travel, if known.
- Nature of the risk or any observed train activity.
- Time of sighting.

Network Rail

Any dog reported on, or in immediate danger of entering, railway tracks or railway infrastructure should also be reported to:

Network Rail 24-Hour Emergency Helpline:

03457 11 41 41

Provide:

- Exact location.
- Description of the dog.
- Direction of travel.
- Details of any person who has entered or attempting to enter the railway environment.
- Any immediate hazards or train movements observed.

6. Immediate Actions and Scene Management

Where a dog is confirmed or suspected to be within a railway environment, volunteers should:

- Maintain a safe distance at all times.
- Observe and record the dog's location and movements where safe to do so.
- Avoid any actions that may encourage the dog onto railway tracks.
- Withdraw if conditions become unsafe.
- Relay information to coordination teams and emergency services as appropriate.

Volunteers must not attempt to rescue, pursue, or contain a dog whilst it remains on railway property.

7. Operational Intelligence and Information Sharing

Information gathered through visual observations, reports from members of the public, or other sources must be treated as supporting intelligence only.

All tactical decisions must:

- Prioritise volunteer and public safety.
- Be made from safe, non-railway land.
- Be consistent with instructions provided by British Transport Police, Network Rail, or other emergency services where engaged.

Observations and relevant information may be shared with emergency services to support a coordinated response and safe resolution planning.

Where emergency services have been requested but have not yet attended, volunteers should provide updates through the appropriate communication channels. If there is a significant change in circumstances, increased risk, change in location, or new information that may affect the response, volunteers should contact 999 to provide an update.

8. Dog Movement Away From Railway Land

Where a dog has safely moved away from railway property and onto accessible land, volunteers may consider low-stress techniques to encourage the dog to remain away from the railway environment.

Consideration may be given to:

- Calm positioning to encourage movement away from danger areas.
- Allowing the dog time and space to settle.
- Using familiar voices or scent-based food items where appropriate.
- Maintaining observation from a safe location while coordinating the next steps.

Any approach should remain calm and non-threatening, avoiding actions that may cause the dog to panic or return towards railway property.

9. Lone Working

Volunteers attending incidents involving railway environments should avoid lone working wherever reasonably practicable.

However, as Lost Dogs Ayrshire cannot guarantee that two or more volunteers will be available at all times, lone working may occasionally be unavoidable.

Where lone working cannot be avoided, volunteers should:

- Inform another team member of their location and intended actions.
- Ensure they have a clear route away from the area if required.
- Maintain regular communication through the organisation's approved communication channels.
- Provide updates at appropriate intervals.
- Avoid isolated locations where personal safety may be compromised.
- Withdraw immediately if they feel unsafe or if circumstances change.

- Notify the appropriate team member when leaving the incident location and confirm when they have safely returned home, returned to work, or resumed their previous activity.

If communication cannot be maintained, or the volunteer believes the situation has become unsafe, they should withdraw and reassess whether it is safe to continue.

10. Use of Drones (Observation Only)

Consideration may be given to the use of drones to monitor and track the movements of a loose dog, particularly where the dog is in an area that is difficult to access safely or where aerial observation may assist in maintaining visual contact without placing volunteers at risk.

The use of drones is for observation and tracking purposes only. Under no circumstances should a drone be used to:

- Herd, chase, or deliberately influence the movement of a dog.
- Drive a dog away from, or towards, any location, including railway lines, railway property, or volunteers.
- Fly in a manner that may cause distress to the dog or create an additional risk to public safety.
- Encourage or influence the movement of a dog onto, along, or across railway infrastructure.

Any drone operations must comply with current UK Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) regulations, including CAP 722 and the UK Drone and Model Aircraft Code, and must only be undertaken by suitably competent operators in accordance with any applicable airspace restrictions. Particular consideration must be given to any airspace restrictions associated with railway incidents, emergency service activity, or infrastructure locations.

The safety of the dog, volunteers, members of the public, railway operations, and other airspace users must remain the primary

consideration when deciding whether the use of a drone is appropriate.